

Impasto

Oil paint can retain the crisp shape of a brushstroke, so it is well suited to the impasto technique. If you mix two colors together loosely and apply them with a brush, you can create a rich striated color effect with a highly textured quality. Impasto can also be

useful if you need to work quickly or on a large scale so that you can cover a surface with thick, expressive brushstrokes. Impasto is a technique that relies very much upon making every brushstroke achieve exactly the right feel and sense of immediacy, so many artists who work in this way often scrape off an area that doesn't work and make the impasted brushstroke again.

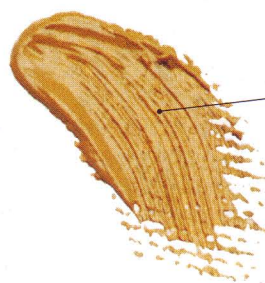
Retaining the shape of a brushstroke

An impasto technique can echo the appearance of the image being painted. Here the rough texture of a shell is reflected in these chunky brushstrokes. Applied wet-in-wet, the thick strokes of paint intermingle slightly so that streaks of color accentuate the textural effect of each brushstroke.



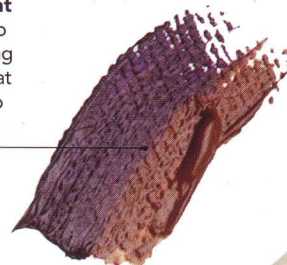
Lively brushstrokes

Painted largely with primary hues mixed with white, this image is built up with small touches of impasted high-key color. No color has been mixed with more than one other hue. Secondary blue-greens and oranges also predominate, vying with the yellows and reds. Touches of pure white have been added last for the highlights. Placed side by side, these separate brushstrokes create a lively patchwork of vibrant color.

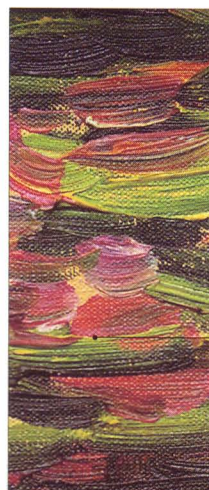


Impasted brushstrokes heighten the rich, buttery quality of oil paint.

Thick paint can pick up light shining on it so that it seems to sparkle.



Thickly applied oil paint retains the marks or ridges left by a brush.



Loosely painted impasted brushstrokes break up the surface of a painting to create expression and vitality.



Rich impasted colors and brushstrokes dancing in all directions are held in check within the "arrow head" composition of the two figures.